

Tufte inspired Typst template (in Quarto)

The Tufte-Memo Usage guide and background

AUTHOR ONE

An Organization
email@email.com

NOAH GULA

github.com/nogula

CHRISTOPHER T. KENNY

github.com/christopherkenny

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This Quarto template adopts many aspects of the design and typography of Edward Tufte’s books and extends nogula’s Typst template. This is the serif-only variant that uses the main serif font throughout instead of switching to sans-serif for headers and other elements.

Introduction

Edward Tufte is an American statistician, professor, and pioneer in the field of data visualization, known for his work on the visual presentation of data and information. He is the author of influential books such as “The Visual Display of Quantitative Information” [1] and is renowned for his principles on clarity, precision, and efficiency in data graphics. His books have inspired a unique design and typography, created by Howard Gralla.

This template adopts many of the conventions used by Gralla and Tufte and allows the interested author to obtain a similar appearance to style of Tufte’s publications. However, the design adapts the book-format to work as an article (i.e., not having multiple parts and chapters and so forth, but instead something more akin to a memo or academic journal article).

This document is a skeuomorph⁰ of the template; it intends to demonstrate the template’s functionality across various frontmatter styles, citations, figures, and importantly, sidenotes.

[1] Tufte, E. R. (2001) *Visual Display of Quantitative Information*

⁰ This document is not only a skeuomorph, but also tests the template itself.

Using this template

This template will function primarily as a normal Quarto template and requires no special configuration to use the basic features. However, to get full use of all Tufte-style features, you may find

some additional features useful. To support this, the ([christopherkenny/typst-function](#)) filter is embedded.

The next sections demonstrate how to use wideblocks, side notes, and figures in the margin.

Note on Quarto 1.9 Marginalia: Quarto 1.9 introduced the Marginalia package for Typst, which provides standard article layout features like `.column-margin` classes and `reference-location: margin` settings. However, this template uses its own custom sidenote implementation via the `note()` function, which is optimized for the Tufte aesthetic. These two approaches can conflict when both are enabled. This template recommends using the custom `note()` function for best results with the Tufte design. If you prefer Quarto's standard margin layout features, consider using a simpler document without this custom template.

You should keep the following in the document metadata:

```
functions:
- note
- wideblock
```

You are welcome to add to this, but removing these will limit your ability to use wideblocks (full width elements) and `note` (margin-only elements).

Wideblocks

You may have noticed that this text spans the entire width of the page whereas the preceeding two pages were compressed to a four-inch-wide column in the typical manner of Tufte books. The template makes permissible the ability to break the narrow column format when desired by using a Typst-based `#wideblock()` function, which takes a single required argument representing the content to be displayed. The simplest way to use the wideblock is by using a div:

```
::: {.wideblock}

your content

:::
```

The wideblock simply is a Typst `block` but with the width parameter adjusted to make the block 6.5 inches wide. This can be use-

ful when a full page does not contain any sidenotes and otherwise the text would look somewhat awkward being unnecessarily compressed into a narrow column.

Sidenotes

In Tufte books, sidenotes¹ are a distinctive feature: they are used for a variety of purposes, but mainly to provide non-critical but related information. In a basic sense, they are simply footnotes but put on the side, appearing closer to the text being referenced.

This template implements sidenotes with a custom Typst `#note()` function. The simplest sidenote is created with `[enter your content here]{.note}`:

²

The sidenote is automatically numbered like a footnote. This numbering can be disabled with the `numbered: false` argument:

Sidenotes are most typically set with a span, `[text]{.note}`, which is converted to Typst code via the `typst-function` filter.

The `note()` function uses the `drafting` package and supports the `dy` argument to adjust the vertical offset. This is helpful when multiple notes are positioned close together:

³

The `note()` function can contain any content, including figures, tables, and other formatted elements.

Citations in the Margin

Citations follow the standard Quarto citation syntax. When you create a citation, it will be included in the bibliography at the end of your document.

Figures

Figures can be displayed in three different ways. A standard figure, which sits within the body text can be placed as normal, without any special configuration. This is demonstrated with Figure 1, below. These figures only occupy the four-inch-wide space making up the width of the document.

¹ This is a sidenote; perhaps you have already noticed them in this document.

² This is an example sidenote

This sidenote is not numbered.

³ This note is offset down the page.

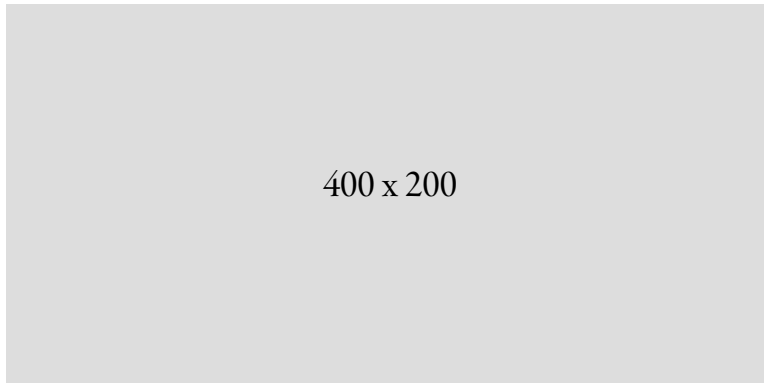


Figure 1. This is just a plain figure.

Second, a `wideblock( )` can be used to display a larger (or, at least wider) figure in the text, which spans 6.5 inches rather than four. This is demonstrated with Figure 2.

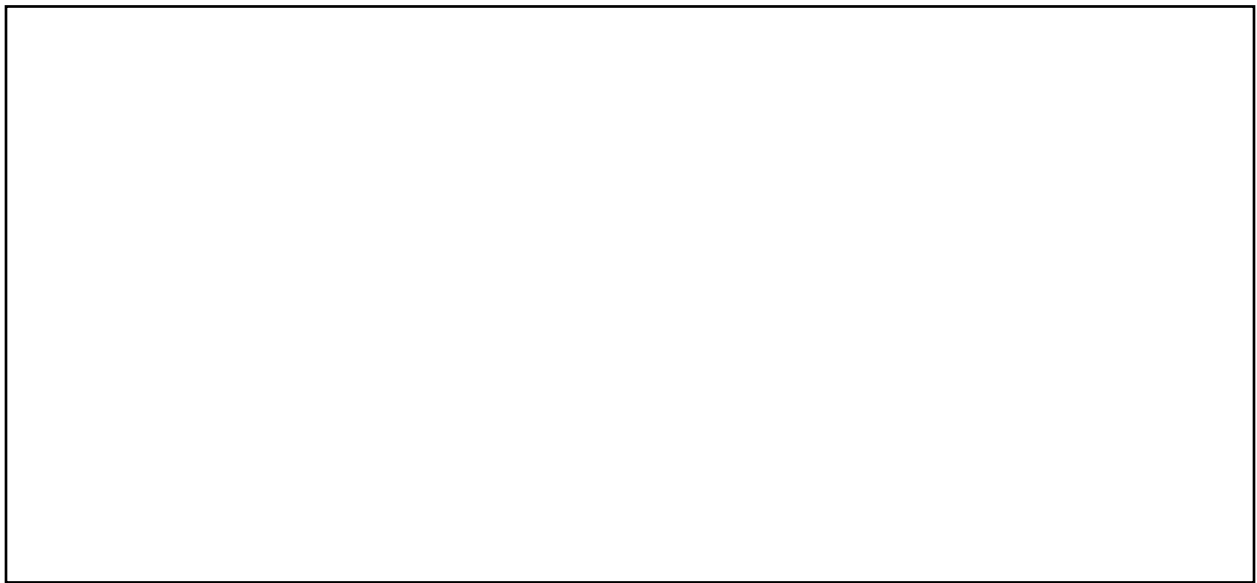


Figure 2. The widest figure you've ever seen!

Note that this figure also demonstrates the ability to place raw Typst blocks within figures. You can mix and match as you see fit, but I strongly recommend using the basic figure formatting from Quarto, otherwise you may need to manually control figure kinds and their respective counters. In general, if you use Quarto syntax where possible and only resort to raw Typst at the last moment (like above using `#rect` only after setting up the figure), things should work.

Third, you can also display figures in the margin. Figure 3 demonstrates this. You can adjust their location using the `dy` argument to `note()`. You can use any `Typst` length, including inches (“in”) or centimeters (“cm”). This note is moved 1.2 inches down on the page.

Other Formatting

This template supports headings up to and including the third level. Levels below this are supported, but will use standard Quarto styling.

Text is displayed with a modest lightness (`luma(30)`) to reduce the harshness of the contrast between the type and the paper; links are displayed underline like `<www.example.com>`.

To start a bibliography on a new page, it is recommended to use the `{< pagebreak >}` `shortcode` which is included in Quarto automatically.

Epilogue

nogula’s original thanks

Thank you to Edward Tufte for inspiring this template, and to other Typst contributors, particularly Nathan Jessurun for drafting.

christopherkenny’s thanks

Thank you to nogula for building the Typst template from which this Quarto template is built.

References

- [1] E. R. Tufte, *Visual Display of Quantitative Information*, Second. Cheshire, Connecticut: Graphics Press, 2001.

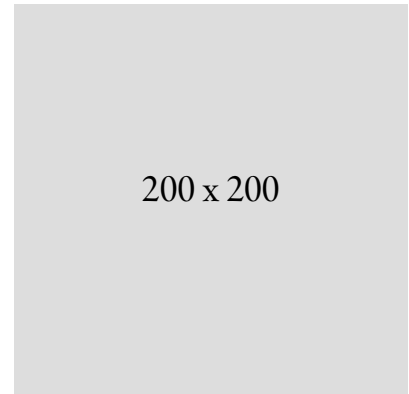


Figure 3. This is a little figure in the side-notes.